

TYPES OF PREPARATION

If you are interested in practicing one or more of these approaches, look for dedicated childbirth classes in your area.



Mind

» Hypnobirthing is a form of self-hypnosis where you consciously take calm control of your birthing experience with breathing and relaxation techniques. You remain fully aware and focused throughout (you are not in some kind of hypnotic “sleep”).

» Audio-analgesia uses a combination of music and white noise to help you control and dull the sensation of pain.



Spirit

» Relaxation, meditation, and mindfulness can clear your mind of thoughts and block out what is going on around you while you remain calm, aware, and centered (below). Find a warm, quiet space. Lie down. Gently stretch out your arms, legs, shoulders, wrists, shoulders, and neck. Get comfortable, close your eyes, breathe regularly, and focus on an object or the present moment.



Body

» Squatting opens out your pelvis to ease the baby's passage through the birth canal. Stand up straight with the back of a sturdy dining chair facing you. With your feet hip-width apart, toes pointing slightly outward, and hands on the chair back, bend your knees until you're in a sitting position. Push your weight into your heels. Push up from your thighs. Repeat five times.

Clear your mind and still your emotions Concentrate only on the present moment and the rise and fall of your hands on your chest

Breathe evenly Keep a regular rhythm. Breathe in through your nose and blow out through your mouth

Calm your body Breathe in deeply to boost the amount of oxygen you inhale. Relax all your muscles with each inhalation

Cross your hands over your chest Focus on the rhythm of your breathing

Sit cross-legged Choose a soft surface on the floor and sit with your back upright. Relax your inner thighs to help to open your pelvic girdle



CHILDBIRTH PIONEERS

You might find the writings of some of the different childbirth philosophers and practitioners inspirational when considering the type of birth you want.

» **Dr. Ferdinand Lamaze** investigated effective relaxation and breathing techniques, now known as “Lamaze breathing.”

» **Frederick Leboyer** seeks to reduce the trauma of birth, saying that babies should be born into calm, softly lit surroundings and placed on the mother's skin before the cord is cut. He is also an advocate of water births.

» **Sheila Kitzinger** enabled women to reclaim some control over the way they want to give birth. She campaigned for the avoidance of unnecessary obstetric intervention where appropriate so that giving birth is a powerful, positive experience.

» **Michel Odent** endorses active childbirth techniques, thereby reducing the need for pain relief and the number of assisted deliveries and cesarean sections.

Learning to relax Try focusing your awareness on your natural breathing rhythm to link your emotions and thoughts to your physical sensations. The more relaxed you are, the less tension, and therefore pain, you will experience.